

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

SECTION A - Socio-Political Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

(a) Explain the distinction between a claim-right and a liberty, and show why the distinction matters for the relation between the individual and the state. [10 marks]

Model answer (145 words; practice model, not official): The distinction. A claim-right is a justified claim whose correlative is a duty in a determinate other: my right against assault is your duty not to assault me. A liberty or privilege is a freedom to act whose correlative is merely a no-right in others: nobody may demand that I desist, but nobody is bound to assist me either. Why it matters. First, it disciplines rights-talk. Claims of the form "I have a right to X" are inflated whenever no bearer of a corresponding duty can be named. Second, it fixes what the state owes: liberties require forbearance, while claim-rights may require provision, protection and remedy, which is a far heavier institutional demand. Verdict. The distinction therefore separates what the state must merely not do from what it must actually do - and confusing the two produces either hollow entitlements or an unbounded expectation of provision.

(b) "Corrupt practices reveal an inherent tension between particularistic and universalistic normative standards." Do you agree with this statement? Give reasons and justification for your answer. [10 marks]

Model answer (190 words; practice model, not official): Position. I agree, and the weight falls on "inherent": the tension is ineliminable because it lies between domains, not between rival moralities. The two standards. Particularistic norms weight family, caste, friendship or patronage; universalistic norms require impartial application of public criteria. Why particular duties are genuine. This step makes the tension inherent. Personal relations generate real duties, not bias to be suppressed; were they mere temptation there would be no tension, only weakness of will. The four-step argument. Personal relations generate genuine duties; office is entrusted for a specified common purpose; discharging private loyalty through office costs unrepresented citizens; corruption occurs when a legitimate loyalty is acted upon in a role governed by universal standards. The characterisation. Corruption is therefore a category error of role executed for advantage - a valid norm imported into a domain that excludes it. The remedy that follows. Not the abolition of personal loyalty but the definition of role boundaries, conflicts of interest and recusal - role-differentiation rather than the suppression of duty. Limit. Boundaries work cleanly for discrete decisions and poorly for pervasive influence, informal networks and agenda-shaping, where recusal has nothing to attach to. Verdict.

(c) "Merit is a moral entitlement." Examine this claim. [10 marks]

Model answer (190 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The claim conflates two criteria operating in opposite temporal directions, and it is false as stated. The distinction. Desert is backward-looking and moralised: it tracks what a person has done, sacrificed or suffered, and governs honours, recognition, praise and blame. Merit is forward-looking and functional: it tracks who will discharge a role well, and governs offices and appointments. A candidate may have great desert and little merit, or great merit and no desert. Why the conflation matters. Treating merit as a moral entitlement converts a claim about fitness for a task into a claim about what is owed. The strongest objection to merit itself. Measured merit encodes prior access to nutrition, language, coaching and networks, so a selection score is partly a record of others' investment. Rawls presses further: natural talent, family advantage and even the capacity for effort are morally arbitrary, since nobody deserves the starting position from which effort is exerted. The reply. Rawls does not conclude that desert is meaningless. Legitimate expectations generated within just institutions remain valid, and honour and gratitude remain intelligible responses to effort. What collapses is desert's claim to be foundational. Verdict.

(d) Compare socialism and communism as two distinct political ideologies. [10 marks]

Model answer (191 words; practice model, not official): Declare the vocabulary first. In Marxist usage "socialism" often names a transitional lower phase; in wider political theory it names the whole family. This answer uses the wider sense, and the distinction is drawn against communism as the Marxian higher phase. Four axes. Property: socialism means social control in varied forms - public, cooperative, guild, worker or mixed; communism means common control with classes abolished. State: socialism may retain a democratic and active state; communism expects the political state, as an instrument of class domination, to lose that function. Distribution: socialism may use contribution, need or mixed principles; communism distributes according to need in the higher phase. Method: socialism may be revolutionary or gradual; communism is reached through transition. Why they are distinct in kind. Socialism is a family admitting utopian, Marxian, Fabian, guild, market and Gandhian members, and leaves the state, the distributive principle and the method open. Communism specifies all three. A doctrine that leaves questions open is not a milder version of one that closes them. Control. Neither is identical with social democracy, which retains private property under regulation, operates a welfare-regulatory state and proceeds by constitutional reform. Verdict.

(e) Do you agree that the rights concerning land and property have empowered women? Discuss. [10 marks]

Model answer (199 words; practice model, not official): Reading the stem. The verb is "have empowered", so this is a conversion question. Establishing that such rights exist answers a question that was not asked. The record, classified. The Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, 2005, is an enacted amendment giving daughters in a Mitakshara joint family coparcenary status by birth on the statutory terms. Vineeta Sharma v. Rakesh Sharma (2020) is a Supreme Court judgment clarifying that right, including that the father need not have been alive at commencement. Together they settle entitlement and interpretation. Why that is not empowerment. Four conversion failures, none of them a defect in the law: waiver pressure, framed as family loyalty; informal partition, keeping the division outside the record; record practices, maintained by the social order the law was meant to change; and fear of family rupture, which attaches a relational price to claiming. Where the failures sit. All four operate at the access, control, return and exit levels - inside the household. That is why the property question becomes the public/private question. The concession. The recognition gain is real and independent: equal inheritance marks daughters as full members rather than temporary dependants, and that status change does not wait on possession. Verdict.

Q2

(a) "Human rights and human dignity would no longer be the product of a particular culture, rather a common human aspiration for an ideal world." Discuss. [20 marks]

Model answer (315 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The statement is defensible in the precise form it uses: human rights express a common human aspiration, not the property of one civilisation - provided universality of aspiration is not confused with uniformity of institutional articulation. The universalist claim. Human-rights theory holds that certain rights belong to all human beings simply as human beings. Its argument is that moral concern can be universalised beyond citizenship, religion and culture, and its ground is dignity, equal worth and protection against cruelty, arbitrariness and degradation. Its presupposition is a minimum moral horizon common to humanity. The relativist challenge. Conceptions of personhood, community, authority and obligation differ across traditions, and the vocabulary of individual claim-rights is historically particular in its formulation. Traditions organised around role, duty and reciprocity may reasonably resist translation into an idiom not their own. Adjudicating the tension. The two positions answer different questions. On the ground of dignity, the universalist holds that every human has equal worth while the relativist holds that dignity is interpreted through culture; the defensible line is that core protections may be universal while institutional expression varies. On rights language, the historical point about Western formulation is conceded; universality of aspiration need not imply uniformity of articulation. On community against individual, rights can be read relationally - as protections of persons within relationships - without losing protective force. The Indian dharma idiom illustrates this: it condemns cruelty and enjoins restraint while beginning from obligation rather than claim, which shows that the aspiration is not idiom-bound. Verdict. The stem is right that dignity is a common aspiration rather than a cultural product, and wrong if read as requiring one institutional form for all. The residual difficulty is genuine: which protections belong to the non-negotiable minimum, and who fixes the boundary, remain disputed - but a universality that can be waived by cultural appeal would protect nobody, and that is the one concession analysis should refuse.

(b) "Duties are of the nature of obligation while Rights are of the nature of entitlement. Therefore there is no necessary connection between the two." Do you agree with this statement? Give reasons and justification for your answer. [15 marks]

Model answer (292 words; practice model, not official): Position. I agree with the statement's premise and reject its inference. Obligation and entitlement are genuinely distinct concepts; but analytic distinguishability does not entail the absence of a necessary connection. Conceding the premise. Duties are obligations to do, avoid, respect or support; rights are justified claims, liberties, powers or immunities. The two are analytically distinguishable, which is why we have two words rather than one. Refusing the inference - the Hohfeldian split. "Right" names four juridical positions, each with its own correlative: a claim-right correlates with a duty; a liberty correlates only with a no-right in others; a power correlates with liability; an immunity correlates with disability. Therefore correlativity is strict for claim-rights - my right against assault simply is your duty not to assault me - and absent for liberties, since a liberty imposes no positive duty of assistance. The connection is conceptual for one class of rights and institutional for the rest. Why the connection is not dispensable. Rights are socially actionable, not isolated metaphysical ornaments. A legal right to remedy implies institutions' duty to hear claims. Two consequences follow: entitlements without correlative obligations remain empty, and obligations without any corresponding claims risk authoritarianism. The concepts are distinguishable but not socially separable. The strongest point on the other side. For liberties the correlativity thesis really is false as stated, so a candidate who claims that every right entails a duty has overreached. The honest position concedes this rather than defending an untenable universal. Verdict. Not agreed as a whole: the premise is sound, the inference invalid. Logical strictness does not hold for every use of "right", but normative necessity does - a right-worthy order requires duties somewhere in the background, and the two are inseparable in practice even where they are separable in analysis.

(c) "Guilt is individual; responsibility admits of collective forms." Critically examine this claim in the context of mass violence. [15 marks]

Model answer (297 words; practice model, not official): Position. The claim is correct and is the most important control in this area, because "collective responsibility" conceals at least five different claims. The five kinds, distinguished. Criminal guilt - this person planned, ordered, incited or committed; defensible, and attaches to individuals only. Organisational liability - a body with decision procedures and a chain of command answers for what it decided; defensible where the body has genuine agency. Political responsibility - members of a polity bear responsibility for what is done in their name and by their institutions; partly defensible, grounding reparation, memory and reform, never guilt. Moral responsibility for omission - bystanders who could have acted at acceptable cost bear some responsibility; defensible but graded by knowledge, capacity and risk. Metaphysical or inherited guilt - guilt by ancestry or membership; rejected, because it is the very logic that generates atrocity. Why differentiation is required. Mass violence fragments agency through dehumanisation, moral exclusion, diffusion of responsibility, bureaucratic routine and suppressed

dissent. Arendt's account of wrongdoing performed through cliché, careerism and failure of judgment describes that setting exactly - but concerns the psychology of perpetration, not the degree of guilt, and must be stated so, or it reads as an excuse. Critical examination. Objection: political responsibility is incoherent, since citizens who opposed the policy, who were children, or who had no effective voice cannot owe reparation merely by membership. Reply: the category is grounded in membership of an ongoing institutional order whose acts were done in the members' name and whose liabilities they inherit - a structure familiar from corporate and successor-state obligation - and it yields duties to repair, remember and reform rather than blame. Residue: the reply is weakest for those who had no effective voice, on whom the duty may fall most heavily despite their being least able to prevent the wrong. Verdict.

Q3

(a) "Punishment is a constrained practice, not a free exercise of state power." Discuss with reference to corruption, mass violence and capital punishment. [20 marks]

Model answer (388 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. Punishment is legitimate only as a constrained practice: its aim may be forward-looking, but its application is bound by legality, culpability, proportionality, dignity, procedure, equality and a preserved route back to membership. The three applications test those constraints differently. The constraints, stated. A defensible punishment presupposes a public law known in advance; a voluntary act or relevant omission; proportionate culpability; fair procedure and reliable proof; a competent and impartial authority; proportionality between wrong, responsibility and sanction; and equal application without status bias. Each blocks a specific abuse, and naming the abuse converts the list into an argument. Corruption - pressure on the concept of a public wrong. Victims are diffuse and no assault occurs, so the harm-based case for criminalisation is weak. The constraint holds because the wrong is the betrayal of entrusted office and the displacement of public rules by private access - wrongs surviving where no measurable loss is shown. Remedy follows diagnosis: attack monopoly, discretion and impunity, with certainty of detection as the operative lever. Mass violence - pressure on attribution. Division of labour, bureaucratic routine and diffused responsibility fragment agency, tempting an answer either to acquit everyone below the leadership or to convict a community. The constraints forbid both: guilt is individual, while responsibility admits collective forms - organisational liability, political responsibility grounding reparation, memory and reform, and graded responsibility for omission - inherited guilt being rejected outright. Arendt's thesis is psychology, not a reduction of guilt. Capital punishment - pressure on every constraint at once. The penalty is irreversible and eliminates the agent whose responsibility, capacity for reform and rights grounded the constraints. Desert may be granted and still cannot be reliably administered through a fallible, unequally resourced process; incapacitation fails necessity once secure imprisonment exists; deterrence is contested, and the burden under uncertainty lies with whoever proposes the irreversible penalty. Bachan Singh (1980) is a judgment, Law Commission Report No. 262 (2015) an advisory report. Objection and reply. Objection: so many constraints leave the state unable to punish effectively. Reply: they do not reduce the capacity to punish the guilty; they reduce the capacity to punish conveniently - which is their whole point. Verdict. Punishment is constrained or it is power: corruption tests whether a public wrong needs a visible victim, mass violence whether responsibility survives fragmentation, and capital punishment whether any constraint holds where error is uncorrectable.

(b) Compare Berlin and Green on the meaning of liberty, and assess whether their positions can be reconciled. [15 marks]

Model answer (295 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. Berlin and Green fear different failures, and their positions are reconcilable at the level of institutional design while remaining opposed at the level of authorisation. The axis of dispute. The question is not how much freedom each wants but what destroys it. Berlin's anxiety is coercion exercised in the name of a higher freedom; Green's is formal liberty accompanied by no power to use it. Berlin at full strength. Negative liberty asks within what area a person is left alone; positive liberty asks who governs her and by what self she is directed. Berlin does not deny the appeal of self-mastery; he identifies the step that makes it dangerous - the split between a "real self" and an "empirical self", after which a ruler may claim to speak for the first and present coercion as liberation. His background commitment is value pluralism: human goods are many and not always harmonisable. Green at full strength. Liberty is the positive power to do or enjoy something worth doing or enjoying, tied to self-realisation. Mere non-interference is hollow where persons are crippled by ignorance, addiction, destitution or social subordination, so coercion is not freedom's only enemy: disabling conditions also matter. Education is the standing example, because it equips agency rather than merely leaving persons alone. The reconciliation. The two are compatible if positive freedom is read as enabling rather than perfectionist: institutions may enlarge a person's effective capacity while leaving the choice of ends with her. On that reading Green supplies what Berlin's negative pole omits, and Berlin supplies the constraint Green's programme needs. Where reconciliation fails. It fails at authorisation. If any agency is empowered to identify what is "worth doing", the real-self structure reappears, and no agreed test separates enablement from prescription in contested cases. Verdict.

(c) Are Marxian Socialism and individual freedom consistent? Discuss critically. [15 marks]

Model answer (228 words; practice model, not official): Fix the concept of freedom first. The stem is decided by which conception is in play. For Marx, freedom is non-domination together with self-development, not merely the absence of interference; the question "freedom from whom, and for what activity?" is therefore prior. The case for consistency. Marx criticises equal legal right where formally identical rules operate over radically unequal social conditions: formal liberty coexists with structural dependence when workers lack independent access to the means of production. On this account collective ownership is not a restriction on freedom but its material precondition, since it removes the standing power of some over others' work and life-chances. The case against. Collective ownership specifies who does not own; it does not by itself specify who decides. Where "collective" power becomes bureaucratic command, the worker exchanges a private superior for an official one, and the standing subjection that the concept of freedom was introduced to remove reappears intact. M. N. Roy states the internal criticism precisely: dictatorship cannot reliably serve emancipation, because concentrated power reproduces domination. The conditional verdict. Marxian socialism and individual

freedom are consistent only if collective ownership enlarges real self-development and democratic control. If it does not, the emancipatory claim defeats itself. Residual. Marx supplies no institutional mechanism guaranteeing the condition, and the Critique of the Gotha Programme two-phase account is a normative projection rather than a demonstrated law.

Q4

(a) Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawls's theory of justice. [20 marks]

Model answer (331 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. "Improvement" is criterion-relative. Judged by reach into realised lives, Sen improves on Rawls; judged by institutional determinacy and the protection of basic liberties by rule, Rawls retains the advantage. The criterion must be stated before the verdict. Rawls at full strength. Principles are chosen in the original position behind a veil of ignorance, yielding equal basic liberties with lexical priority, then fair equality of opportunity, then the difference principle. The construction answers the aggregation objection: no one may be sacrificed for a larger total, because no chooser can gamble on occupying someone else's position. Sen's criticism. Sen distinguishes *niti* - the correctness of institutions, rules and procedures - from *nyaya*, justice as actually realised in people's lives. A society may have fine rules on paper and produce grave injustice in practice. He therefore rejects transcendental institutionalism: we can identify manifest injustices and rank alternatives without first agreeing on a perfectly just basic structure. The metric. Sen replaces primary goods with capability - what persons are actually able to do and to be - because disability, age, gender, climate, health and social position change how resources convert into functioning. Equal income does not yield equal mobility or voice. First objection and reply. Comparative judgement without a benchmark may under-determine the choice between two rival improvements. Sen answers that public reasoning and manifest injustice supply enough orientation, and that demanding a complete ideal before acting is itself a source of paralysis. Second objection and reply. Capability comparison is measurement-heavy and open-ended. Sen prefers reasoned public assessment to spurious exactness, deliberately declining a rigid final list - a defensible choice for plural societies that nonetheless costs determinacy. What Rawls still does better. Institutions remain the indispensable precondition of any realised justice, and the lexical priority rule protects liberty by rule rather than by ongoing judgement. Verdict. Sen improves on Rawls in diagnosis and reach and does not displace him in institutional design; the honest ruling is that the two are complementary, with priority decided by the criterion invoked.

(b) Discuss gender as a cultural category as opposed to sex as a biological category. [15 marks]

Model answer (269 words; practice model, not official): How to read "opposed". As contrasted, not partitioned. The two are categories of different things - bodily and reproductive characteristics on one side, socially produced roles, expectations and identities on the other - but they interact, since pregnancy, illness and ageing are at once bodily and socially organised. The contrast, stated. Sex names bodily and reproductive characteristics, with the qualification that biological variation is more complex than a rigid social binary. Gender names socially produced roles and identities. Gender hierarchy names the patterned ranking of masculinised over feminised roles - and not every difference is discriminatory; unjust subordination is the issue. How a cultural category acquires force - six channels. Family allocates food, education, inheritance and mobility. Language supplies the unmarked default. Labour decides which work is paid and which is "natural". Law governs succession, guardianship and marriage. Media fix the repertoire of imaginable lives. Sanction - ridicule, exclusion, coercion - attaches a cost to departure. The sixth channel is what converts a norm from a description into a constraint. Construction is not unreality. Money, citizenship and caste are socially constructed and all three are enforceable. Construction is a claim about origin, not about strength. The depth marker. Butler presses further: the categories through which bodies are read as sexed are themselves produced within a gendered discourse, so gender is sustained by compelled reiteration rather than expressed from an inner essence. The category-stability objection and the strategic-essentialism reply must travel with it, and the exchange is live. Verdict. Gender is cultural in origin and material in effect: made by institutions, and distributing opportunity, rights and resources as reliably as any natural law would have done.

(c) Distinguish civil disobedience from conscientious objection, resistance and revolution, and examine whether a constitutional democracy can consistently accommodate any of them. [15 marks]

Model answer (261 words; practice model, not official): The four rungs. Conscientious objection aims to avoid personal complicity, may be private, seeks exemption and typically accepts the penalty, and accepts the system's legitimacy. Civil disobedience aims to persuade the majority, is essentially public, breaches a specific law with acceptance of legal consequences, and appeals to the system's own principles. Resistance aims to obstruct a specific grave injustice, may be covert, may refuse the penalty, and denies the legitimacy of the acts obstructed. Revolution aims to replace the constitutional order, is organised and often armed, and denies the system's legitimacy wholesale. The two defining features of civil disobedience. Publicity with appeal to shared principles, and acceptance of the legal penalty - the second being what demonstrates that the actor contests one law rather than repudiating law as such. Non-violence is standardly added; on the Gandhian account it is constitutive, since means and ends are inseparable. Can a constitutional democracy accommodate them? It can accommodate the first two without contradiction, because both accept the order's legitimacy and neither claims a legal right to disobey. No legal order can recognise a right to civil disobedience, since acceptance of the penalty is part of the concept. In India, Articles 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(b) protect protest subject to reasonable restrictions; they do not protect law-breaking, and Article 51A is non-justiciable. Verdict. Accommodation is moral and political rather than legal: the order tolerates and learns from penalty-accepting dissent, while resistance and revolution answer to progressively heavier burdens of justification. Ambedkar's objection stands wherever constitutional channels are genuinely open to the group in question.

SECTION B - Philosophy of Religion

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

(a) Write an essay on Spinoza's notion of God and His attributes. [10 marks]

Model answer (159 words; practice model, not official): Spinoza rejects the creator-creation dualism of classical theism. God is the one absolutely infinite substance, expressed by Deus sive Natura - "God, or Nature." Substance exists in itself and is conceived through itself; because an infinite substance excludes any rival of the same attribute, only God possesses full ontological independence. An attribute is what intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance. God has infinitely many attributes, although humans know Thought and Extension. These are not two substances; each expresses the same divine reality. Minds, bodies and events are dependent modes. No finite mode is the whole God. God is immanent, not a transcendent craftsman. Natura naturans is active self-caused nature; natura naturata is the necessary modal order. God does not deliberate among possible worlds. Freedom means acting from one's own nature without external constraint. This secures unity and necessity but abandons personal providence and libertarian choice. Spinoza's God is metaphysically supreme, though not the personal deity of classical religion.

(b) "Toleration granted by the strong to the weak is permission, not equality." Examine. (Answer in about 150 words.) [10 marks]

Model answer (144 words; practice model, not official): The statement is correct, and its force comes from the power component in the concept of toleration itself. Toleration requires three things: an objection to what is tolerated, reasons that outweigh without cancelling that objection, and the power to interfere combined with deliberate restraint. The third condition means that toleration is always exercised by someone who could have done otherwise. Forst's ladder makes the consequence explicit. Permission is the powerful allowing a minority to exist on sufferance; coexistence is a pragmatic modus vivendi; respect is reciprocal recognition as equal moral-political persons; esteem positively values the other's beliefs. Only respect and esteem are compatible with equal citizenship, and most historical toleration was permission. Vivekananda reaches the same conclusion from the other direction, demanding acceptance rather than toleration because toleration still condescends. Toleration is thus indispensable - the objection component makes it a moral achievement - and insufficient.

(c) Explain why classical Mimamsa is often regarded as the sharpest counterexample to the claim that religion requires God. [10 marks]

Model answer (189 words; practice model, not official): Because it removes God from a tradition that keeps everything else religion is usually thought to need: scripture, ritual, duty, merit and a promised fruit. Three functions a deity normally performs are reassigned. Authority: the Veda is authorless (apauruseya), so no speaker's reliability needs establishing, and the theistic arguments from the text's status lose their premise. Duty: Jaimini's Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2 defines dharma as what is characterised by injunction and is beneficial, so dharma is known from injunction alone, not from any deity's command. Desert: unseen potency (apurva) is postulated to connect a perished momentary act with a much later fruit, answering the Nyaya demand for a superintendent of karma. The deities named in the mantras are elements within the ritual structure - the dative of the offering - rather than agents who hear and grant. Two qualifications are owed. Nyaya objects that an unconscious potency cannot select the right fruit for the right agent; Mimamsa replies that the relation is law-like rather than deliberative, which the objector must then argue against. And later authors of the school drift toward theism, so the atheistic reading is of the classical system.

(d) Does the doctrine of divine simplicity strengthen or weaken the notion of a personal God? Give reasons for your answer. [10 marks]

Model answer (175 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. Non-composition (divine simplicity) strengthens the metaphysics of a personal God and weakens its religious grammar; the verdict must therefore be graded rather than flat. The doctrine. Simplicity denies every composition in God - matter and form, substance and accident, essence and existence - so that wisdom, goodness and power name one identical reality under different creaturely modes of conception. Aseity, the claim that God derives nothing, is its close companion. The strengthening reason. Whatever is composite depends on its parts and on whatever unites them; a first, underived ground cannot be dependent. Simplicity therefore secures precisely the non-derivation that makes God worth calling ultimate rather than merely greatest. The costs. Two objections bite. Modal collapse: if God is identical with the divine act of will and exists necessarily, whatever is willed appears necessary, so creation loses contingency. Plantinga's objection in Does God Have a Nature? presses that if God is identical with a property, then God is a property, and no property is an agent who knows or loves. Verdict. That narrowing is the real cost.

(e) Is there any compatibility between 'Freedom of Will' and 'Omnipotent God'? Discuss. [10 marks]

Model answer (161 words; practice model, not official): Omnipotence should mean the power to actualize every logically possible state of affairs consistent with divine nature, not constant exercise of exhaustive control. Human freedom, minimally, requires that some actions issue from the agent rather than from external compulsion. On these definitions, compatibility is possible. A creator may endow persons with secondary causal agency and refrain from determining each choice. Such self-restraint is an exercise of power: permission differs from inability to control. Moral responsibility presupposes this sphere. The difficulty is sharper if freedom requires the categorical ability to do otherwise. An omnipotent God could override every choice; moreover, infallible divine foreknowledge appears to close alternatives. The standard reply distinguishes knowledge from causation and, on a timeless model, denies that God first predicts and then fixes the act. Yet non-causal certainty may still threaten alternative possibilities. Thus omnipotence and agency are conditionally compatible if divine power can sustain non-coerced secondary causes. Libertarian freedom remains difficult when omniscience and providence are added.

Q6

(a) All evil is either sin or punishment for sin." - St. Augustine. Critically discuss. [20 marks]

Model answer (372 words; practice model, not official): Augustine's sentence partitions all evil into sin and its punishment. The metaphysics behind it must be stated before it is tested. Being, insofar as it is being, is good; God creates beings, not evil substances; corruption is parasitic, depending on a good nature to corrupt; and moral fault is disordered willing. Evil is therefore privation of a due good (privatio boni), not a rival creative principle. Privation does not make pain unreal: rot is not a rival substance to wood but the real loss of the wood's proper integrity, and blindness is a determinate lack in a creature whose nature calls for sight. On this basis the partition works as follows. Moral evil is sin - the misuse of created freedom. Natural evil is punishment - the consequence of a fallen, disordered order following the Fall. The critical half has four parts. First, innocent suffering: infants and the congenitally afflicted fit a retributive reading poorly. Second, animal and pre-human suffering: no free-will defence and no retributive account applies to a creature that neither chooses nor sins, and a cosmic fall preceding human history is historically and scientifically strained. Third, the metaphysics of privation is strained for intense positive pain, which does not feel like an absence. Fourth, and most sharply, inherited guilt: the claim that later persons are personally guilty for an ancestor's act is far harder to defend than the claim that they inherit a damaged condition and a disordered social-natural order. The second reading reduces the objection but still owes an account of why a good creator permits the condition and its unequal effects. Two comparators sharpen the verdict. Hick's soul-making replaces punishment with development: humans are created immature, at an epistemic distance, in a law-governed world where courage and compassion become possible. Indian karma replaces a single Fall with a beginningless series and thereby answers the distribution question - why this person - that Augustine cannot; its own cost is unverifiability and the risk of victim-blaming. Verdict: treating the printed sentence as the object of analysis rather than as a certified translation, the thesis succeeds for moral evil and preserves divine goodness in creation, but it is incomplete for natural, innocent and animal suffering, where a developmental or distributional account does more work.

(b) Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil. [15 marks]

Model answer (270 words; practice model, not official): Process theodicy answers evil by revising omnipotence, not by justifying permission. Its tenets are six. (1) Creativity, not God, is the ultimate; actual entities are self-creative occasions of experience. (2) God is dipolar: the primordial nature is the ordered envisagement of possibilities, supplying each occasion its initial aim; the consequent nature receives and preserves what the world becomes. (3) Power is intrinsically distributed: to be actual is to possess some self-determination. (4) Divine power is therefore persuasive by metaphysical necessity - for Griffin, God cannot coerce, which is what separates process theodicy from the free-will defence, where God chooses not to intervene. (5) Evil is the deviation of finite occasions from the divine lure; God is not culpable because God could not unilaterally prevent it. (6) God is "the fellow-sufferer who understands" (Whitehead) - solidarity, not detachment. The layers must be named separately. Whitehead, *Process and Reality* (1929), supplies the dipolar God, the initial aim and the consequent nature. Hartshorne, *The Divine Relativity* (1948) and *Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes* (1984), argues that classical omnipotence is incoherent: to have all the power is to leave none to anything else. Griffin, *God, Power, and Evil* (1976) and *Evil Revisited* (1991), supplies the metaphysical-necessity move. Cobb's *A Christian Natural Theology* systematises the theology. Criticism: a God who cannot guarantee victory over evil may be unworthy of worship; the metaphysics is contested; and classical theists deny that actuality entails self-determination. The replies are divine solidarity and the objective immortality of achieved value in the consequent nature. Verdict: it purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty - and the trade must be stated, not concealed.

(c) If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine. [15 marks]

Model answer (261 words; practice model, not official): The stem asserts a conditional: absolute creation entails that human agents cannot be responsible for evil. Its scope must be fixed first - it concerns moral evil, since no one attributes an earthquake to a human agent. Three replies resist the conditional. First, the free-will defence: God creates the capacity for choice, while the agent supplies the act. Significant freedom entails genuine alternatives, and God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose rightly - the description cancels itself. A world of programmed beneficence lacks the moral authorship of a world containing genuinely responsible agents. Second, Augustine's privation account: God creates natures, all of which are good as created; evil is a privation of a due good arising in a defective will, so what God creates and what goes wrong are not the same item. Third, foreknowledge is not causation: knowing what an agent will freely do does not make the agent do it. A fourth route rejects the antecedent. Process theism denies that God has the unilateral power the stem presupposes: power is intrinsically distributed, so no being determines another's becoming. The critical half must concede what survives. Even granting that God does not cause the act, knowingly choosing to instantiate the whole system, foreseeing its outcomes, remains morally relevant. Foreknowledge does not cause free action, but it does not discharge the decision to create. Verdict: the conditional is false as stated - creaturely authorship is preserved - but it is not empty. It correctly identifies a residual divine responsibility for the system, which the free-will defence answers by pricing rather than by denying.

Q7

(a) Examine whether the epistemology of deep disagreement strengthens or weakens the case for religious pluralism. (Answer in about 350 words.) [20 marks]

Model answer (342 words; practice model, not official): It does both, and the balance is what makes it examinable. The apparatus. Within a shared framework, the dispute is between conciliationism or equal weight (Feldman, Christensen), on which discovering peer disagreement should reduce confidence, and steadfastness (Kelly, van Inwagen), on which one may retain a belief because one's own reasoning is part of one's evidence; the independence principle - assess the disagreement without relying on the reasoning under dispute - is what conciliationism needs and steadfastness denies. Deep disagreement, in Fogelin's technical sense (1985), goes further: the parties do not share the framework propositions - Wittgenstein's hinge commitments in *On Certainty* -

against which evidence would count, so the same evidence is not evidence for the same thing. Lynch extends the analysis to disagreement about epistemic principles themselves, where any defence is circular. Why religion is a paradigm case. The parties differ over the sources of evidence, the criteria of adequacy - salvation, liberation, cessation - and the framework in which any datum would count. Where it weakens pluralism. Two consequences cut against it. Exclusivism cannot be convicted of irrationality merely for persisting, which removes the easiest charge against it and gives Plantinga's third reply its technical backing. And pluralism cannot be established merely by pointing at persistence - the persistence that seemed to support Hick's first premise is now explained without any pluralist assumption. Where it strengthens pluralism. Two further consequences cut in its favour. The failure of convergence is predicted rather than scandalous, so it is weak evidence for relativism. And what can be rationally required are the procedural virtues - fallibilism, humility, epistemic charity, and willingness to make one's framework explicit - which is precisely the ethic pluralism recommends. Jain conditional predication is the most developed attempt to make framework-relativity explicit inside the proposition. The verdict. Deep disagreement weakens the case for pluralism as a demonstrated metaphysics and strengthens it as an ethic of engagement. Unresolvability is epistemic, not alethic: one party may still be right, and what fails is our capacity to show which. That is a smaller claim than Hick's, and it is more defensible.

(b) Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument. [15 marks]

Model answer (250 words; practice model, not official): The ontological argument claims a unique entailment: that the very concept of God contains, and therefore yields, God's existence. Anselm defines God as "that than which nothing greater can be conceived", where "greater" means more perfect. In Proslogion 2 he argues by reductio: if this being existed only in the understanding, a greater could be conceived - namely the same being existing in reality as well - which contradicts the definition. In Proslogion 3 the claim is strengthened: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; God therefore exists necessarily, by aseity. Descartes recasts this through essence-containment: existence belongs to a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle. The entailment fails at a precise point. Gaunilo's perfect-island parody shows the form proves too much; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary, non-contingent existence, which an island by definition lacks. That reply protects the second form but shifts the burden onto the coherence of maximal greatness. Kant's objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones; existence posits an object rather than enriching a concept. Chatterjee and Datta restate this in the Indian idiom of a hundred rupees imagined in one's pocket. Modal reconstructions retain necessary existence but transfer the whole weight to the possibility premise, which a parallel possibility-of-non-existence can offset. Verdict: the concept entails existence hypothetically, not actually. Conceptual analysis yields a conditional, never an instantiation.

(c) Does religious pluralism require abandoning the claim that any religion possesses absolute truth? Critically discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (210 words; practice model, not official): Pluralism begins from durable disagreement among traditions that are internally complex and supported by serious forms of life. Exclusivism preserves determinate truth but struggles to explain morally and spiritually impressive outsiders. Inclusivism recognises them while interpreting their achievements through one tradition's categories. Hick's pluralism distinguishes the ineffable Real from its culturally conditioned appearances, allowing several traditions to mediate salvific transformation. Critics object that Hick creates a higher-order theory that overrides the self-understanding of each religion and makes the Real too indeterminate to guide belief. Pluralism nevertheless need not mean that contradictory doctrines are equally true. It can combine fallibilism, dialogue and comparative judgment: claims remain answerable to coherence, evidence, moral fruit and their capacity to illuminate experience. Absolute certainty should be abandoned, but truth itself need not be. A defensible pluralism treats traditions as corrigible approaches to reality, permits genuine disagreement and rejects both coercive monopoly and an indiscriminate relativism. It also requires reciprocal openness: each tradition must permit its own interpretation to be corrected through encounter with others. Dialogue then becomes an epistemic practice, not merely a strategy of civic tolerance, while constitutional neutrality protects the conditions under which such inquiry can occur. Pluralism is strongest when it combines humility about possession of truth with seriousness about pursuing truth.

Q8

(a) Present a critical exposition of different arguments offered by St. Thomas Aquinas to prove the existence of God also known as 'Five Ways'. Which one of them do you find philosophically most interesting? Give reasons in support of your answer. [20 marks]

Model answer (382 words; practice model, not official): Aquinas' Five Ways (ST I, q.2, a.3) are five distinct a posteriori arguments, not one argument restated. Each begins from a general feature of the world and concludes with the cautious formula "and this everyone understands to be God" - itself an admission that further work is needed to identify the terminus with the God of religion. Way 1 argues from motion, understood as the reduction of potentiality to actuality: whatever is moved is moved by another, and an essentially ordered series of movers cannot regress infinitely, so there is an unmoved mover. Way 2 argues from an order of efficient causes to a first efficient cause. Way 3 argues from contingency: if everything were merely possible, at some time nothing would have existed, and nothing would exist now; hence there is a necessary being, and ultimately one necessary of itself. Way 4 argues from degrees of goodness and truth to a maximum which causes all perfection. Way 5 argues from the regular goal-directed activity of things lacking cognition to a directing intelligence, as the arrow is directed by the archer. Critically, the excluded regress is essentially ordered - the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick - so "first" denotes explanatory priority, not chronological firstness. Aquinas himself concedes the difficulty of excluding an endless series of events, and holds that the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration; neo-Thomists accordingly recast the excluded series as simultaneous

dependence. Way 3 is vulnerable to a quantifier shift at the step from "each thing at some time is not" to "at some time nothing is". Way 4 requires the Platonic machinery of participation, since degrees of heat do not entail a hottest object. Way 5 is exposed to Hume's analogy objection and, in Paley's later form, to Darwin. Kant's overarching charge is that the passage from "a necessary being" to "the most real being" is the ontological argument in disguise. Most interesting: Way 3. It alone poses the deepest question - why is there anything at all rather than nothing? - and it is the only Way whose central premise, the Principle of Sufficient Reason, remains a live philosophical dispute against brute-fact naturalism. Its conclusion is also modally strongest: not merely a first mover but a being whose non-existence is impossible.

(b) Is morality autonomous from religion even when moral life is interpreted as obedience to God? Examine. [15 marks]

Model answer (214 words; practice model, not official): Divine-command theory gives morality authority, motivation and an objective source, but the Euthyphro dilemma asks whether acts are right because God commands them or commanded because they are right. The first horn risks arbitrariness; the second recognises a standard intelligible apart from command. Modified theories appeal to God's necessarily good nature, yet judgments about goodness are still needed to understand that claim. Kant therefore locates obligation in rational autonomy: fear of punishment or hope of reward cannot constitute a good will. Religion may nevertheless deepen moral life by supplying narratives, communities, exemplars and practices of repentance. Indian traditions also separate the issues: Mimamsa grounds dharma in Vedic injunction without a creator, Buddhism in the causes of suffering, and the Gita joins duty with devotion. Morality is thus normatively autonomous because reasons for action must withstand rational and ethical scrutiny. It need not be culturally isolated from religion, which can interpret, motivate and sustain obligations without being their sole foundation. This distinction also protects believers: a purported command that licenses cruelty must be challenged through conscience, public reason and the deeper ethical resources of the tradition itself. Autonomy is therefore accountable moral judgment, not hostility to faith. Religious motivation remains valuable when it strengthens, rather than replaces, reasons that can be offered to affected persons.

(c) Explain the relation between the God and the Self according to Ramanujacarya. [15 marks]

Model answer (284 words; practice model, not official): For Ramanuja, God is the supreme personal Brahman, while the individual self is a real, eternal and conscious jiva. Their relation avoids both non-dual identity and an external dualism of independent substances. Brahman is one organic whole qualified by cit, the plurality of selves, and acit, matter, and the world is its real transformation (parinama). The decisive concept is aprthaksiddhi, inseparable existence. The self is a genuine qualifier or mode (prakara) of Brahman. It is numerically distinct and morally responsible, yet it cannot exist or be understood independently of God. Ramanuja further expresses this through sarira-sariri-bhava: the jiva is God's body, while God is its indwelling Self (antaryamin). A body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its self. "Body" therefore indicates metaphysical dependence, not divine physical anatomy. This relation explains both agency and devotion. The jiva knows, acts and bears karma; God is the inner governor and gracious end of action, sustaining the capacity to act and consenting (anumati) to its exercise, so moral authorship remains the jiva's. Bondage obscures the full manifestation of the self's consciousness but does not make individuality illusory. Through right knowledge, disciplined action, bhakti and prapatti, the jiva receives grace, and in liberation enjoys communion and service while retaining its identity. Two contrasts sharpen the account. Against Samkara, the self is not Brahman but belongs to Brahman; against Madhva, whose reflection relation (bimba-pratibimba) keeps five eternal differences, Ramanuja's dependence is internal to one qualified whole. The model preserves unity, religious relation and plurality better than numerical identity, yet if every suffering self is God's body under divine control, responsibility for evil remains a serious pressure. The relation is best formulated as real distinction within complete, purposive dependence.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS